At the time of the nuclear tests, India and Pakistan were enjoying a period of relative stability that had begun in the early 1970s. These years were not wholly tranquil and had been punctuated by periods of considerable tension. For example, a serious disagreement had arisen between the two countries during the mid-1980s over alleged Pakistani support for a Sikh separatist movement in the Indian Punjab.[45] Also, since 1989, India and Pakistan had been at loggerheads over the bloody insurgency against Indian rule in the state of Jammu and Kashmir. India accused Pakistan of materially assisting the Kashmiri separatists, while the Pakistanis maintained that they provided the rebels only political and moral support. Indo-Pakistani militarized disputes had become more frequent since the outbreak of the Kashmir uprising than they were during the 1970s and early to mid-1980s, and included the serious militarized crisis of 1990.[46] Nonetheless, despite these problems, the two countries had largely avoided serious confrontation during the nearly three decades since the Bangladesh war. Indeed, they had not fought a war with each other since 1972. This was the longest period without an Indo-Pakistani war since the two countries gained independence from Great Britain in 1947.[47]

In the wake of the 1998 tests, many observers believed that this relatively peaceful trend would continue. Yet less than a year after the tests, India and Pakistan were embroiled in their first war in twenty-eight years. In late 1998, Pakistan Army forces, disguised as local militants, crossed the line of control dividing Indian from Pakistani Kashmir and seized positions as much as seven miles inside Indian territory. The move threatened Indian lines of communication into northern Kashmir. After discovering the incursion in May, the Indians launched a spirited air and ground offensive to oust the intruders. The operation was characterized by intense, close-quarters combat, with Indian infantry and artillery ejecting the Pakistanis from the mountainous terrain peak by peak. Although expanding the war could have facilitated their task, the Indians did not cross the LOC, restricting their operations to the Indian side of the boundary. The Pakistanis finally withdrew in mid-July, after Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif traveled to Washington and signed an